

A Democracy Interrupted

Lesson 22 — Iran before the revolution: the 1953 coup

What you will know and be able to do

1 Explain why Mossadegh's oil nationalisation provoked such a severe British and American response

2 Trace Operation Ajax from planning to execution

3 Explain how domestic Iranian divisions made the coup possible, not just foreign intervention

4 Begin evaluating the coup's long-term connection to 1979

A different country, a strikingly similar pattern

While Egypt moved from monarchy to republic to peace with Israel, Iran followed its own distinct path — beginning, like Egypt's story, with a struggle over who actually controlled the nation's oil.

Nationalising the Anglo-Iranian Oil Company

For decades, the British-controlled Anglo-Iranian Oil Company extracted, refined, and exported Iranian oil while returning only a small share of profits to Iran itself. In 1951, Iran's parliament voted to nationalise the company; Mohammad Mossadegh, an ardent nationalist, became prime minister that same year and made nationalisation his government's central achievement.

Sanctions first, a coup second

Britain responded with sanctions and a global embargo aimed at crippling Iran's oil exports and reversing nationalisation. President Truman initially refused British requests to help remove Mossadegh; his successor, Dwight Eisenhower, proved more receptive, persuaded by British arguments that instability in Iran risked a Communist takeover — despite the CIA's own internal analysis judging such a takeover unlikely.

Operation Ajax, Operation Boot

In March 1953, Eisenhower authorised the CIA to plan a coup jointly with Britain's MI6 — codenamed Operation Ajax by the Americans, Operation Boot by the British. The plan relied on bribery, propaganda portraying Mossadegh as unstable, and paid crowds designed to manufacture the appearance of mass domestic opposition.

Mossadegh's own coalition was already fraying

Mossadegh had increasingly governed through emergency powers, and held a widely criticised referendum on dissolving parliament that returned a suspicious 99.4% approval. Ayatollah Kashani, once a key clerical supporter of nationalisation, broke with Mossadegh entirely and backed the coup — depriving him of crucial religious legitimacy at the decisive moment.

19 August 1953

An initial attempt to arrest Mossadegh failed after he was tipped off, briefly sending the Shah fleeing the country entirely. A second, better-organised effort on 19 August succeeded: paid demonstrators and army units seized Tehran, Mossadegh's home came under fire, and roughly 300 people died in the fighting. The Shah returned the following day.

Reversed in practice, if not in name

A 1954 agreement kept Iranian oil formally “nationalised” while placing a new international consortium — with BP retaining 40% and major American firms taking large shares — in practical control of production and pricing. Iran gained an improved revenue split, but not the sovereignty over its own resource that nationalisation had promised.

SAVAK, and a monarchy without real limits

Restored to full power, the Shah spent the following decades consolidating authoritarian rule, banning opposition parties and building SAVAK, a CIA-assisted secret police force notorious for surveillance, imprisonment, and torture. Mossadegh himself was imprisoned, then confined under house arrest until his death in 1967.

Which fear actually drove the decision?

Historians disagree on Washington's true motive: some emphasise genuine, if exaggerated, Cold War fears of Communist takeover; others argue protecting Western oil interests mattered more, with anti-Communist rhetoric providing convenient cover. Recently declassified material has fuelled, rather than settled, this debate.

A full essay attempt

'Fear of Communism, more than the desire to protect Western oil interests, best explains the American decision to help overthrow Mossadegh.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence about the CIA's own internal assessments and Britain's stated concerns
- Address the strongest counter-argument before concluding

Key terms from today

Anglo-Iranian Oil Company

The British firm whose nationalisation triggered the crisis; later BP.

SAVAK

The Shah's CIA-assisted secret police, notorious for repression.

Operation Ajax / Operation Boot

The CIA and MI6 codenames for the 1953 coup.

Blowback

Unintended, long-term negative consequences of a covert intervention.

What to remember

Mossadegh's 1951 oil nationalisation provoked a joint British-American covert operation that exploited genuine domestic Iranian divisions to remove him in August 1953, restoring the Shah to full, increasingly authoritarian power. The episode is widely regarded as having sown resentments that fed directly into the revolution still to come.

Lesson 23 — The Shah's White Revolution

Next lesson: the ambitious modernisation programme the Shah launched in the 1960s — and the new grievances it created even as it reshaped Iranian society.